StrideForward

A STRIDEFORWARD STARTER KIT

The Customer *Experience* Blueprint Starter Kit.

A short guide and a fillable one-pager for mapping one customer, family, or donor journey — and finding the friction that quietly sends people away.

For leaders of nonprofits, small businesses, and education organizations.

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WHY THIS MATTERS

The customer experience is the strategy.

Most organizations know their programs. Fewer know their *experience* — the sequence of small moments a person moves through from the first time they hear your name to the moment they decide to stay, refer, or leave.

That sequence is where most of the churn happens. It's also where most of the loyalty is built. Chip and Dan Heath call these "moments that matter" — the peaks and pits that shape how someone remembers the whole experience, whether they're a customer, a family enrolling in a program, or a donor giving for the third time.

The good news: you don't need a research firm or a six-figure engagement to find the friction. You need one hour, a small team, and this worksheet.

> **What you'll do with this kit**
>
> Pick one type of person (one customer, one family, one donor). Walk their journey through five stages. Name the friction. Design one moment that matters. Ship one change in the next 30 days.

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SECTION 01

The five stages of a customer journey.

Every meaningful relationship — with a customer, a family, or a donor — moves through five stages. The friction that costs you people usually lives between them, not inside them.

Stage	What's happening	Where friction usually lives
1. Awareness	Someone first learns you exist — from a search, a referral, a flyer, a colleague.	Your name doesn't come up. When it does, what people find first doesn't match the work.
2. Consideration	They're deciding whether to reach out, apply, enroll, or give.	Too many clicks to figure out fit. No clear next step. Silence after they inquire.
3. Purchase / Enrollment	They commit — buy, apply, sign up, donate.	Paperwork friction. Payment or form friction. A wait that feels like being forgotten.
4. Engagement	They're actively in the relationship — using, attending, participating, receiving.	Nothing feels designed for them. They can't find help. They stop being surprised in good ways.
5. Loyalty	They stay, come back, refer, renew, upgrade — or they don't.	No moment of recognition. No easy way to bring a friend. No feedback loop that shows you're listening.

The peak-end rule

Research on how people remember experiences shows they don't average the whole thing — they remember the emotional **peak** and the **end**. Two implications for your blueprint: (1) most stages don't need to be great; they need to be frictionless. (2) One or two stages need to be memorable on purpose. That's what this kit helps you design.

SECTION 02

How to run the 60-minute exercise.

Best done with 2–5 people who touch the customer or family experience. Bring paper, sticky notes, or the worksheet on the next page. Give someone the role of scribe.

1 Pick one persona (5 minutes)

Not "all our customers" or "all our families." Pick one specific type — a first-time donor giving under $500, a family enrolling their first child, a small-business customer choosing between you and one competitor. Name them. Give them a first name if it helps.

2 Walk the five stages (25 minutes)

For each stage, answer three questions: **What are they doing? What are they feeling? What are we doing behind the scenes to support them?** Do it fast. Don't polish.

3 Name the friction (15 minutes)

Read the whole journey out loud. Circle any place where someone would reasonably drop off, get confused, wait too long, or feel unseen. These are your friction points. Star the three worst ones.

4 Design one moment that matters (10 minutes)

Pick one stage — usually engagement or loyalty — and ask: what would make this feel unexpectedly designed *for them*? A note. A call. A small ritual. Something no one else is doing.

5 Ship one change in 30 days (5 minutes)

Not the whole redesign. One friction point removed, or one moment added. Assign an owner. Put it on the calendar.

> **A note on what this is not**
>
> This is not a full service blueprint (that adds the technology, the systems, and the back-stage teams). It's the starter version — enough to find where the friction lives and design your first move. If the exercise surfaces something bigger, that's a sign to invest in the full blueprint.

SECTION 03 · THE WORKSHEET

The customer experience blueprint.

PERSONA NAME

IN ONE SENTENCE

Stage	What they're doing	What they're feeling	What we're doing (back-stage)
1. Awareness			
2. Consideration			
3. Purchase / Enrollment			
4. Engagement			
5. Loyalty			

THE THREE WORST FRICTION POINTS

THE ONE MOMENT WE WILL DESIGN FOR THEM

ONE CHANGE WE WILL SHIP IN 30 DAYS

OWNER & DATE

SECTION 04

Three contexts, same framework.

The five stages hold across contexts. What changes is the language, the friction points, and where the moment that matters lives.

Nonprofit — donor journey

Persona: First-time donor under $500.

Usual friction: No follow-up after the gift. Second ask feels transactional. Impact update is generic.

Moment to design: The 48-hour thank you. Named. Specific. From a person, not a system.

Small business — customer journey

Persona: Customer choosing between you and one competitor.

Usual friction: Consideration stage is silent. First purchase has no ritual. Second purchase has no reason.

Moment to design: The first-purchase moment. Unexpected. Not a discount — a signal you noticed them.

Education — family journey

Persona: First-time family enrolling their child.

Usual friction: Application forms. Silence between apply and start. First-week overwhelm.

Moment to design: The week-before-school welcome. A specific message from a specific person, not a form letter.

The through-line

In all three, the moment to design is small, specific, and human. It costs almost nothing. It shifts the whole memory of the experience because it hits the peak or the end — the two moments people remember.

SECTION 05

Designing a moment that matters.

A useful moment has four qualities. If you're deciding between three ideas, run each through this filter and pick the one that scores highest across all four.

1. Elevated

It stands out from the rest of the experience. It's not the baseline — it's a peak. If it feels like standard operating procedure, it won't be remembered.

2. Specific

It's for this person, not any person. Use their name. Reference something specific about their situation. Generic sentiment doesn't land — it evaporates.

3. Sensory

There's something to see, hear, hold, or feel. A handwritten note beats an email. A phone call beats a text. A physical object beats a digital one.

4. Repeatable

It's designed once, delivered many times. If it only works when the founder does it, it isn't a moment — it's a favor. Design it so anyone on the team can deliver it.

A working example

A small nonprofit's development director wanted a better first-time donor moment. Cost: less than $2 per donor. Design: within 48 hours of a first gift, a handwritten card from the ED with one sentence naming the specific program the donor's gift is supporting that week. Owned by the development coordinator, batched twice weekly. Result over 6 months: second-gift rate on first-time donors nearly doubled. The moment was elevated (unexpected), specific (this donor, this week), sensory (handwritten card), repeatable (batched process).

SECTION 06

What to do next.

This week — 60 minutes

Run the exercise with your team. Fill in the worksheet. Star the three worst friction points and pick your moment to design.

Weeks 2–4 — one shipped change

Ship the one change. Not the whole redesign. Just the one thing you named. Assign one owner and one date. Note what you observe.

Month 2 — the second pass

Come back to the worksheet. What changed for the persona? What did you learn about the other four stages while shipping the first change? Design the next moment.

> **When to bring in a partner**
>
> If the exercise surfaces friction that isn't small — a broken enrollment system, a program model that doesn't fit the audience, a team that doesn't have a shared picture of who they serve — that's a bigger design question. It's the kind of work StrideForward does with clients on customer-experience mapping: two decades of designing programs that work, brought to your actual journey, not a generic template.

Want a second set of eyes on your blueprint?

StrideForward is a senior strategy partner for nonprofit, small business, and education organizations. Customer-experience design is part of how we help turn strategy into practical improvements.

Start a conversation.

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